

KF19 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

In our last lesson, I suggested a plan for a twenty-minute meditation spending five minutes on each of the following four exercises:

1. Write down what is bothering you today or what you are thankful for and tell God about it. Then practice the **3-Minute Breathing Space**.¹
2. Practice the **Maranatha Meditation**.²
3. Practice the **SALT Process**.³ This is where you explore your business.
4. Practice the **Mercy Meditation** focusing on either yourself or another person.⁴

Print out the mindfulness and meditation exercises that you have learned and keep copies handy for easy review. If it works better for you, practice in five-minute segments at different times during the day. You might set up a reminder on your phone. Your goal is to meditate for twenty minutes twice a day, once in the morning and then again later in the day. Take small steps and see what happens.

You might also revisit the **FAITH Process** integration that you practiced in the last meeting. Review the KF teaching notes and choose an area of your life that you would like to explore. You could also sign up for the **KF Compass** to help you review the week’s teachings.

Let’s continue to practice the **Mercy Meditation** and apply it to another person, or you might imagine a situation in which you often find it difficult to offer mercy.

Sit quietly for a few moments. Notice your environment as you breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Draw your mind away from the events of the day, from other people’s business, and from the past or the future, and just focus on what is happening inside your own skin right now. Breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* How do you feel? Do you notice your thoughts wandering? Where do they go? Just notice and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now, engage your mind to respond to each of the following three questions for thirty seconds:

1. In what areas am I most critical of another person? (Repeat) (Pause for 1 minute)

Pause, and if you haven't already done so, take a moment to jot down what came to mind. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. For what do I need to forgive this person? (Repeat) (Pause for 1 minute)

Pause. Write down what came to mind. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. How do I treat this person when he or she violates my claims and shoulds? (Repeat) (Pause for 1 minute)

Pause. What came to mind? You might write that down. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now experiment with bringing compassion to this person. Use your imagination in a healthy way to call to mind someone who loves that person as he or she is today. Imagine seeing your chosen person through the eyes of that love. Observe whatever comes to mind, and breathe. As you exhale, practice letting go of your claims and shoulds. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. When you practice this meditation, you are planting seeds of mercy, not only for others, but also for yourself.

Our hymn for our next KF Confession is *My Faith Looks Up to Thee*. Ray Palmer wrote these words in 1830 after seeing Jesus in a vision. You might wish to read the story surrounding this hymn at cyberhymnal.org.

My faith looks up to Thee,
Thou Lamb of Calvary,
Savior divine!
Now hear me while I pray,
Take all my guilt away,
Oh, let me from this day
Be wholly Thine!⁵

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month we are learning about KF Confession 4:

We judged ourselves and others with contempt and felt justified in our wrath.

Our claims and shoulds form a kind of psychic structure—a legal system that provides a framework for making decisions. This framework supports the Idol Self and creates an artificial sense of self-confidence and congruence. Living by the legal system of our shoulds and claims is a way of escaping the laborious effort required to build a skilled, mindful, and meaningful life.

In nearly every area of our society, we are invited to make judgments based on shoulds and claims. Legal systems dictate what should or should not be and motivate nearly everything we, as a society, do, think,

and feel. Our own legal systems provide a cozy cage that confines our minds, restricts our choices, and narrows our perspective. If we have already judged what is right or wrong, we feel secure even when our reactions are misoriented, and we feel right, alive, and busy even in the midst of unhealthy or destructive outcomes. Our strong reactions to the violation of our legal systems validate our egocentric choices and give us the strength to keep insisting on our own way. Legal systems are the misoriented substitute for the laborious effort that healthy people invest in developing the quiet self-confidence that springs from a skilled, mindful, and meaningful life.⁶

We may fear that without our shoulds and claims we would have no motivation at all and would simply drift through life. That possibility is too disturbing to consider, so we cling to our legal systems in order to avoid the imagined shame or humiliation of living unproductively or being at the mercy of others or circumstances. We fear that without the guidance of our legal systems we will feel confused, thwarted, or out of control and punish ourselves with self-hate. We are terrified of making mistakes that would bring us face to face with the truth of our limitations. These fears become our excuse for avoiding the difficult work of developing an inner operating system based on love and applying the wisdom of that system to our lives.

I know a self-effacing woman who started the difficult work of investing in her True Self because she wanted emotional and physical healing more than she wanted to satisfy the compulsive demands of her Idol Self. Within a few months, she became strong enough to confront a dominating friend and set some boundaries. The friend's reaction was explosive, and the self-effacing woman endured a vicious attack followed by weeks of hostile silence. The woman became so uncomfortable with the strained relationship that she began to plan how she might reconcile with her dominating friend. The dictates of her Idol Self were telling her that in order to be loving she should appease and comply. Under relentless pressure from her Idol, she decided to sacrifice her real development and satisfy her self-effacing shoulds. As she prepared to write a card of reconciliation, the Holy Spirit plainly spoke to her. He said, "If you do that, you will not be healed," and because physical healing was more important to this woman than meeting the demands of her Idol, she was able to lay down her pen and wait. A few months later, she was miraculously healed. Her choice to follow the dictates of her self-effacing Idol had been blocking her healing. Since a healthy life invites expansive development, the woman's self-effacing Idol had been resisting every effort she made to improve her health. When she chose to abandon her pride system and defy her Idol Self, she showed God her willingness to cooperate with Him in the development of her True Self. The arrogant-vindictive friend soon found people who were willing to comply and appease in morbid dependency, and the friendship gradually dissolved.

This woman did not have worksheets, but you do. You may, however, feel sleepy or resistant while doing them. You may even feel like you are undergoing major surgery and struggling to resist the knife. That's because your Idol Self and demonic forces do not want you to break their hold on your life; you are undermining their survival. So, don't rely on your feelings while you do your KF work. KF training is exactly like a workout at the gym. You do the work regularly in the hope that you will see results over time. In any workout, you must move against resistance in order to get strong. This is true in the gym, and it's also true in KF. If you do not exercise, you will not get strong. Remember our motto: *Train hard. Fight easy.*

When we exercise at the gym, we don't do all the possible exercises at once. We do a few here and there according to what we need. You can use the same strategy for your work in Karis Fellowships. Your basic exercise is the KF meeting, so a KF workout starts with meeting attendance. If you cannot attend a meeting, however, schedule time to listen to the recording or read the teaching notes. Try to answer a few questions on your **Meeting Preparation Guide**. That in itself is healing. During the week, set aside

time to practice some form of meditation. As you learn the different KF tools, use the ones that seem to fit your present need. Ask your Karis Link to help you.

Replace the thought, “I should do my KF work,” with the question, “What outcome do I want?” (Repeat) Look at the list of Beatitudes that Jesus has given you.⁷ Do you want the outcomes that He tells you will make you favored and happy? What outcomes in your life do you really want? Let’s get real. Your choices tell you what you really want.

If you are willing to work toward the outcomes that Jesus describes, you will experience all kinds of rewards along the way, like increasing trust, joy, and the pleasures of gratitude. Each step forward is success. Remind yourself that perfection is not your goal. Instead, teach yourself this affirmation: *Every effort is success. (Repeat)* You are successful whenever you attend a meeting, do a worksheet, read Dr. Horney’s book, practice meditation, review the teaching notes, or fill out your **Meeting Preparation Guide**. Little by little, you gain a new vision for your life that reflects the Beatitudes—a vision of inheritance, authority, harmony with the Creation and with others, compassion, gentleness, real satisfaction and fulfillment, peace, and the increasing ability to see who God is and what He can do. Tell God and others what you want. Seek, using all the support and tools offered to you. Knock when the opportunity to explore presents itself.

When you unload your shoulds and claims, you are investing in your True Self, and you become authentic enough to explore what you really want. Untrammelled by compelling needs, you are able to access and explore your free will, perhaps for the first time in your life. You can learn to distinguish between the compelling needs of the Idol and your real wants, and you can grow into the kind of person who is able to freely enjoy the fulfillment of those wants. Personal development takes time and training, and when you pursue your real wants out of your True Self, you will have the endurance to go through the process.

Use the **Claim and Blame Worksheet** when you feel entitled to be treated in a certain way by others, by life, or by God. Use the **Shoulds Sheet** when you feel gripped by self-hate. Practice the interventions suggested at the end of the worksheets. By doing so, you are lifting the weights that will strengthen your soul.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord Jesus, help me develop healthy free will so that I can explore my real wants. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

This month we are learning about KF Confession 4:

We judged ourselves and others with contempt and felt justified in our wrath.

In our last Bible lesson, we looked at the Beatitudes in the Gospel of Matthew, chapter 5. We learned that it is much healthier to be motivated by the desire for real happiness than to be driven by the taskmasters

of our legal systems. Do you believe what Jesus says about happiness? Do you want the outcomes that Jesus promises you, or do you really want something else? Your choices will reveal the truth about what you want. For example, your choice to do your KF work reveals your intention to grow and your desire to cooperate with God. Your efforts show Him that you mean business about being happy and gaining His promised rewards.

Let's look at another passage that encourages us to make choices about what we want. This is my paraphrase of **First Peter 3:8–12**.

⁸My purpose in teaching you about husbands and wives is to train the whole community to be harmonious and compassionate, having the same mutual commitment toward one another, to be like loving siblings, to have healthy bowels and the ability to stay inside your own skin; ⁹not returning hurt for hurt, or insult for insult, but doing just the opposite. Bless each other by speaking well and resist any vindictive triumph for this reason: you were called into blessing and praise so that you might inherit blessing and praise. ¹⁰Let me quote this proverb: "Those who desire to live well—to love and experience good days—reveal that intention by refusing to give voice to the pride system of the Idol Self and speak the harm on the tip of their tongues. ¹¹They must turn away from misorientation and do good. They must seek peace and pursue it." ¹²Why is this proverb famous? Because the eyes of the Lord are upon oriented people and His ears hear them express their needs and wants, but the face of the Lord is against those who choose misorientation and do harm.

Take a deep breath.

Just before this passage, Peter has been teaching about the relationship of marriage. Did you know that even though marriage is a legal contract, it is also a *karis* relationship? In his book *Getting the Love You Want*, Dr. Hendrix explains why marriages built on legal systems are full of conflict, while marriages based on positive mutual exchange grow in love. The purpose of Peter's teaching is to guide us in all our relationships, both in the intense laboratory of marriage and in our interactions with our community.

The success of a relationship is directly related to the number of positive interactions between the people involved.⁸ Both giving and expressing gratitude are positive interactions. This is why cultures develop systems of etiquette and good manners. No matter how you feel, you can choose to act and react with good manners. Good manners provide beneficial limitations or boundaries that maintain a positive quality of engagement and protect the trust necessary for healthy growing relationships. These manners rein us in when we feel compelled by volatile moods or egocentric pride to choose misorientation.

The basic Greek word that I've translated as *speaking well* and as *blessing and praise* has entered into the English language as the word *eulogy*. We often think of a eulogy as a funeral speech extolling the qualities of a person who has died, but here Peter is saying that receiving blessing and praise in our lifetime is the inheritance of oriented living.

The reference to bowels in this passage seems archaic, but Peter knew what he was talking about. Medical researchers now know that the gut holds an enormous number of neuroreceptors and functions as a "second brain".⁹ These receptors actually store and release the chemicals of emotion, and the chemistry of our emotions often determines our choices. We want our neuroreceptors to store the most positive emotions possible so that we can love life and enjoy good days.

When we respond to life with blessing and praise, we invite healthy relationships. Scientists say that they can determine the health and longevity of a relationship in about fifteen minutes of observation.¹⁰ What are they seeing? If we could look in a mirror, we might see what they see. We might see how inauthentic and reactive we are. We adhere to legal systems because we do not trust ourselves—and because we do not trust ourselves, we cannot trust others. If we do not trust others, we impose law on them in an attempt to control them. This desire to impose law and control others may be motivated by the fear of losing control of ourselves.

Just like every other system in this material world, relationships are subject to real cause and effect. Misoriented behavior pushes all relationships into further distrust and fear. When we react with the bad manners of imposing, manipulating, or withholding, we block a future inheritance of blessing for ourselves and for others. We might tell ourselves the story that we can treat others badly and then, with a simple apology, reset the relationship to its former comfort and trust, but that is not true; it is an illusion.

When my husband and I are at odds with each other, we can now quickly recognize the misorientation; we know that either both or one of us is misoriented. We have trained ourselves over the years to refuse to react out of our feelings. Instead, we express gratitude and admiration until we can get to a worksheet and resolve those feelings. No matter who is right or wrong, our feelings and our reactions are our business. When we are in our right minds, we revisit the problem together. We train hard, and by doing so we protect our relationship from further ravages of self-hate.

In our passage from First Peter, we see some very clear *do's* and *don'ts*. *Do's* and *don'ts* are necessary. They show us how to get what we want. Peter teaches that if we desire life, love, and the Lord's favor, we first must pay attention to our words. Do your words offer grace, or do they impose your claims and shoulds?¹¹ Our words tell us a lot about who we are, and who we are produces the outcomes of our lives. Next, we must identify our misoriented behavior. Are you aware of unproductive patterns that you repeat over and over again? Unhealthy repetitive patterns are probably compulsive. Have some compassion on yourself, but get real! If you want the kind of life and love that Peter is talking about, you will have to loosen the deadly grip that the Idol has on you—and to do that, you will need God's help. Do you want God's help? If you do, you can prove it to Him by your choices. Train hard with your KF tools. Refuse to do damage. Choose good and avoid harm. Do whatever it takes to learn to live in peace with others and within yourself. You cannot get God's substantial help in any other way.

By offering positive interactions in any situation, you give a karis gift—a gift that invites communion in a safe environment. Every positive effort you make to build human relationships fulfills the logos, God's way of doing things, and strengthens your personal relationship with God.

You will always get what you've always got if you always think what you've always thought. Let me repeat that: You will always get what you've always got if you always think what you've always thought. Our job in Karis Fellowships is to change our thinking. Changing our thinking changes our choices, and changing our choices changes our outcomes. You are here to change what you think in order to get something new. Paul teaches in Second Corinthians that in Christ you are a new creation. Old things and old thinking have passed away; and look!—all things are becoming new.¹²

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord, help me change my choices and create new outcomes. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe.

(Pause for 10 seconds)

Here is our integration focus: *Consider telling God what you really want. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few phrases that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider telling God what you really want*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow what you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. Observe whatever tension you may be feeling as you *consider telling God what you really want*. *(Pause)* Your wants at this time are probably misoriented, but that doesn't matter. Give yourself permission now to explore your wants without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing as you *consider telling God what you really want*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what futility, shame, or perhaps wonder feels like in your body. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider what you really want* today. Does that feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* What do you believe about your wants? *(Pause)* Are your desires based on past experiences or family systems? Do your desires support your real, designed glory or do they support your pride system? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with the long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you inhale, think: *Welcome*. *(Pause)* Invite your desire into your space, not to be judged as either good or bad but to be blessed as your want. It doesn't matter whether the want is oriented or misoriented right now. Welcome your want in for a chat and a cup of tea. Breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, welcome the Holy Spirit into the conversation and give Him permission to explore your desire. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* If you learn something, welcome what you learn. You might wish to jot it down. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

As you breathe, hold your desire in a tender place of compassion and listen to the following statements. On the exhale, let go of any compulsive need that may surround this desire.

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- Although I want this thing, I let go of my longing for power and control.
- Although I want this thing, I let go of my longing for esteem and affection.
- Although I want this thing, I let go of my longing for security and comfort.
- Although I want this thing, I let go of my longing for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time together of healing and training. Hold us in the power of this new direction as You guide us to our real glory and to living a life of truth. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and mission, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ Zindel Segal, J. Mark G. Williams, and John D. Teasdale, *Mindfulness-Based Cognitive Therapy for Depression* (New York: Guilford Press, 2013), 208. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

² John Main, *Monastery without Walls: The Spiritual Letters of John Main*, ed. Laurence Freeman (London: Canterbury Press Norwich, 2006), 32.

³ See KF11.

⁴ www.livingmindfully.org. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

⁵ *My Faith Looks Up to Thee* by Ray Palmer (1808–1887), youtu.be/X5g-Att0bmE.

⁶ Isaiah 32:17.

⁷ Matt. 5:3–10, KF18.

⁸ Divorce Predictors Negative Relationships: Couples Retreats: Relationships Marriage: Gottman, gottmancouplesretreats.com/about/research-findings.

⁹ www.scientificamerican.com/article/gut-feelings-the-second-brain.

¹⁰ www.gottman.com/blog/this-one-thing-is-the-biggest-predictor-of-divorce.

¹¹ Eph. 4:29.

¹² 2 Cor. 5:17.